

CRANBERRIES *Vaccinium macrocarpon*

Cranberries are native to North American bogs, where they thrive in alternating layers of acidic organic matter and sand—as long as you can provide them with the same conditions in your garden, these attractive, spreading bushes will thrive. Although most varieties are generally too sharp to eat fresh from the bush, they are excellent used in cooking, especially in juices, jams, and, of course, cranberry sauce.

	SPRING	SUMMER	FALL	WINTER
PLANT				
HARVEST				

PLANTING

Cranberries need a constantly moist, although not waterlogged, soil with an acidic pH of between 4–5.5. It is probably unlikely that you will find these conditions naturally occurring in your garden, so consider growing cranberries in a container, where you can easily control their soil pH and moisture levels, or dig a dedicated cranberry bed, 6–8 in (15–20 cm) deep, and line the insides with plastic mesh or perforated plastic sheeting.

Cranberries are self-fertile, so you will only need one plant to produce a crop. Plants are supplied container-grown, so can be planted at any time of year. Saturate the soil with rainwater, which has a more acidic pH than



Control conditions in a cranberry container.

tap water, and then plant out the bushes 12 in (30 cm) apart. Leave 12 in (30 cm) between rows. Mulch around the plants with about 1 in (2.5 cm) of sand.

CROP CARE

Water bushes regularly with rainwater, ensuring that the soil is always kept moist. Cranberries are low, spreading plants and may need pruning, either after